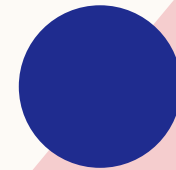


FATHER TO SON

- ELIZABETH JENNINGS

GENERATION GAP

Generation gap is a situation in which older and younger people do not understand each other because of their different experiences, opinions, ideologies, habits and behaviour.





ELIZABETH JENNINGS (1926-2001)

Elizabeth Jennings is one of the most significant poets of the 20th Century. She was born in Lincolnshire on July 18, 1926. She lived most of her lives in Oxford. Her works intensely relates personal matters in traditional and objective style. This prolific writer's consistent devotion to poetry yielded over 20 books during her life. The poetic genius died on October 26, 2001 , in a care home at the age of 74.

FATHER TO SON

I do not understand this child
Though we have lived together now
In the same house for years. I know
Nothing of him, so try to build
Up a relationship from how
He was when small. Yet have I killed
The seed I spent or sown it where
The land is his and none of mine?
We speak like strangers, there's no sign
Of understanding in the air.
This child is built to my design
Yet what he loves I cannot share.

FATHER TO SON

Silence surrounds us. I would have
Him prodigal, returning to
His father's house, the home he knew,
Rather than see him make and move
His world. I would forgive him too,
Shaping from sorrow a new love.
Father and son, we both must live
On the same globe and the same land.
He speaks: I cannot understand
Myself, why anger grows from grief.
We each put out an empty hand,
Longing for something to forgive.



PARAPHRASE 1

6

The father unhappily reflects on his inability to understand his own son. They have been staying in the same house for years but, due to non- communication and a lack of understanding, both son and father are not able to understand each other. The father does not know much about his son's interests, likes or dislikes. Thus, he try to build up the same kind of relationship as he used to have when his son was a little child.

PARAPHRASE 2

The father tried to sow the seeds of love in his son's heart but since the heart belongs to his son, it was up to him whether to nurture those seeds into plants of love or dig them out and throw them without bearing any fruit. There is lack of understanding and a communication gap which makes them behave not like father and son, but more like strangers. The father says that physically the child resembles him but he can not share what his son likes.





PARAPHRASE 3

8

Silence surrounds their relationship because there is a complete lack of communication between them. The father sees his son as a prodigal (a character from New Testament Parables of Jesus) and wants him to return to the home he has always known, so that they can rebuild the relationship to have a new start. He does not want the son to start life afresh without the father. He further says that he is willing to forgive his son for running away. Here the father's tone is somewhat condescending, implying that the father is unable to let his son go, despite restricting the son's independence and development.

PARAPHRASE 4

Both fathers and their sons all over the world must learn to live together in spite of their misunderstandings and differences. While he appreciates his son exploring new love, lands and ups and downs in life, his grief grows bigger as he feels dissociated from his son. He feels anger at having lost his son in his process of growth. However, he realises that they are both in the process of forgiving and hope to reunite.



POETIC DEVICES

- 1) Antithesis: In this figure of speech two contrasting or opposing ideas are put together. For example:
 - (a) The land is his and none of mine
 - (b) Shaping from sorrow a new love

- 2) Alliteration: This indicates occurrence or repetition of the same sound or letter at the beginning of most of the words in a sentence. For example:
 - (a) Silence surrounds us
 - (b) The seed I spent or sown
 - (c) The home he knew
 - (d) Shaping from sorrow

POETIC DEVICES

- 3) Metaphor: In this figure of speech, an implied comparison is made between two unlike things that actually have something in common. For example:
- (a) The land is his and none of mine
 - (b) We both must live on the same globe and the same land
- 4) Simile: Eg: We speak like strangers
- 5) Assonance: The repetition of vowel sounds in words that are close together in a sentence or verse. For example:
- (a) There's no sign of understanding in the air



THANK YOU